

Reducing Risks to Computer Systems

Data breaches, identity theft, and violent crime-whew! These are all possibilities if you don't take proper safety precautions. Don't worry, this checklist will help you to protect confidential information and company systems.

- **Do not leave clients unattended in the office:** Everything in your office, including your desk, purse, phone, files, personal effects, computer, and client files, are all potentially at risk from thieves and other criminals. Do not leave clients alone in an area where these things could be compromised.
- **Lock your desk:** MLS print-outs, client files, and password clues could be stolen from your desk.
- **Lock your computer when not in use:** Your computer contains confidential client, company, and personal information. It is a gateway to all of your company's systems and assets. Leaving your computer unlocked means that anyone could access it-and all of the information and systems on it. This jeopardizes the security of clients, the company, and you-not to mention your future as a salesperson if you are the cause of a data breach.
- **Encrypt email and Internet activity:** Encryption turns information into undecipherable code.
- **Use secure sites: "https":** Websites with an S provide encryption or authentication.
- **Perform file back-ups:** This ensures you can recover data if files are lost or damaged.
- **Perform software updates:** Software updates often provide patches for security issues.
- **Do not click on suspicious links or attached files:** Do not click on links from people you don't know or on unsolicited links from others. If a file is attached to an email from someone you don't know, do not click on it. This could install a virus or Trojan horse on your computer system.

[Source: National Association of REALTORS[®], REALTOR[®] Safety at the Office," <http://www.realtor.org/videos/realtor-safety-at-the-office>]